

105

Philadelphia CDCs Catalogued
(full dataset)

1968–2025

Range of Founding Years
(n=90)

119

Leadership Records Compiled
(full dataset)

2 yrs

Median Completed ED Tenure*
(n=41 sample)

\$793K

Median Annual Revenue
(range \$0–\$74M, n=67)

1 Introduction & Research Question

Community development corporations (CDCs) are local, place-based nonprofits pursuing "community development": low-income housing, workforce development, economic development, and occasionally healthcare or education. First established in the late 1960s as a decentralized response to top-down urban renewal, CDCs are independently governed, and no comprehensive, verified record of their leadership histories exists for any city.

Guiding question: What can the histories of Philadelphia CDCs reveal about how community organizations adapt to and preserve institutional knowledge through leadership change?

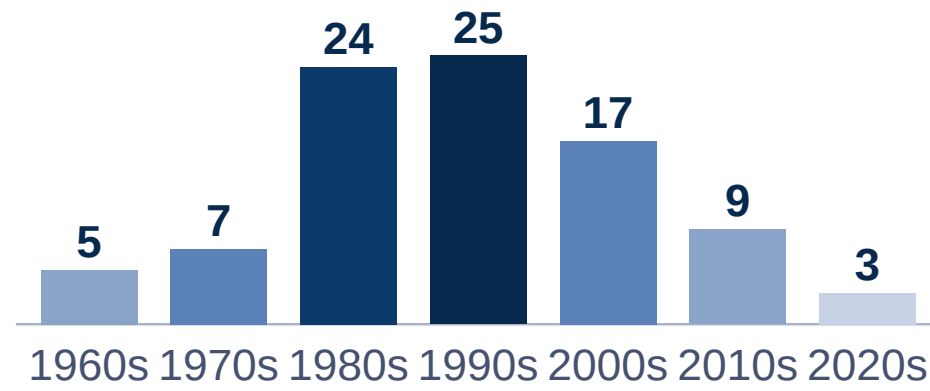
2 Building the Dataset

A historical record was constructed for each CDC (founding date, mission, leadership rosters, organizational changes), drawn from Form 990 filings, corporate registries, news archives, and org websites. To correct for publication bias, a **random sample of 20 CDCs was cross-checked year-by-year for 1968–2025**, building a verified timeline independent of who happened to be publicly documented.

Challenges encountered while compiling records:

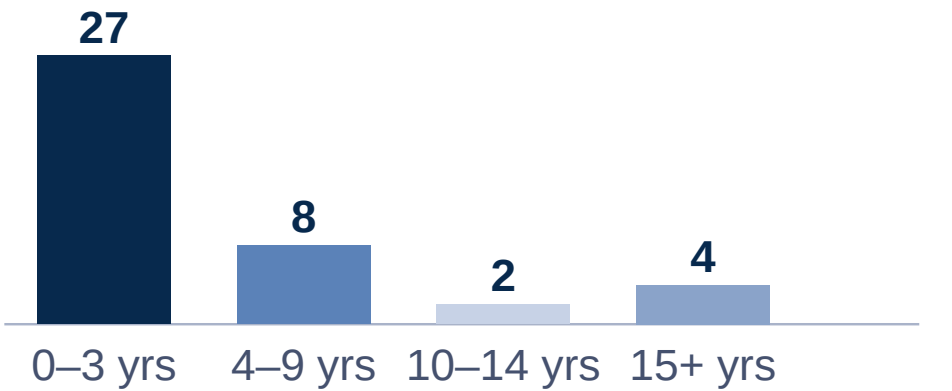
- Fragmented, conflicting, or missing public records for many small/older CDCs
- Federal tax IDs (EINs) sometimes misattributed between organizations, requiring independent verification of every record

3 When CDCs Were Founded



Founding decade of catalogued CDCs (n = 90 with identifiable founding year; earliest confirmed CDC founded 1968). More than half (49 of 90, 54%) were founded during the 1980s–90s wave of federally-supported community development.

4 Leader Tenure Distribution (verified sample)



*Completed ED tenures (n = 41) from a random sample of 20 CDCs with full year-by-year leadership coverage, 1968–2025 (currently-serving leaders excluded to avoid undercounting). Median tenure is just 2 years, but a long tail of founder-directors serve 15–46 years; mean (6.2 yrs) is pulled upward by that tail.

5 Leadership Transitions & Institutional Memory

Across the dataset, leadership is a defining force in CDC identity: strategic direction, funder relationships, and community trust are frequently concentrated in one long-serving executive director rather than distributed systems, creating both stability and fragility.

A survivorship bias in the public record: leaders who stay decades are the ones news coverage and Form 990s document best, which is why an initial pass suggested long tenure was typical. The verified sample says otherwise: **median completed tenure is just 2 years**. In this sample, short completed tenures are far more common than the public record initially suggested.

PATTERNS OBSERVED

- Founder-anchored orgs:** single long-tenure leader, strong documented continuity, but succession risk
- Multi-transition orgs:** frequent change, fragmented records
- Planned successions** tend to preserve mission & partnerships
- Leadership talent circulates:** directors move between CDCs, carrying knowledge across organizations

6 Comparing CDC Histories: Case Studies

PLANNED EXIT, ROCKY AFTERMATH · EAST FALLS DEVELOPMENT CORP.

Gina Snyder, ED 2003–2017

A textbook "planned" succession, a year's notice, board-run search, and 3-month overlap, still wasn't enough. The org churned through two short-tenure EDs, Kathleen Hogan and Meredith Johnson, before stabilizing for several years under Michelle Feldman. A new ED took over in 2025, and the full quote behind this transition anchors the poster below.

DEATH IN OFFICE, INTERNAL PROMOTION · GERMANTOWN UNITED CDC

Andy Trackman (2012–2020) → Emaleigh Doley → Leo Dillinger IV

Founding ED Andy Trackman led 9 years until his death in 2020; corridor manager Emaleigh Doley was promoted to succeed him. When she left in 2024, the incoming ED reported inheriting few documented systems; as with any transition narrative, that account reflects only one side of the handoff.

"There weren't a whole lot of systems in place... it almost kind of felt like starting a CDC from the ground up."

LEO DILLINGER IV, CURRENT ED

POST-LONG-TENURE CHURN · MANAYUNK DEVELOPMENT CORP.

Multiple Directors → Jane Lipton → Gwen McCauley

MDC also administers Manayunk's Business Improvement District, shaping it toward corridor/business services. After a long-serving director departed, the org cycled through roughly five directors in five years before Jane Lipton rebuilt stability for a long tenure.

"They came in and they flipped out, and they came in and they flipped out, and they came in and flipped out. And then finally Jane came... and created a lot of stability."

GINA SNYDER, ON MANAYUNK'S TRANSITION PERIOD

SUDDEN LOSS, TWICE · NEW KENSINGTON CDC

Sandy Salzman → Felix Torres Colon → Dr. Bill McKinney

Long-time ED Sandy Salzman retired and was succeeded by Felix Torres Colon, who died unexpectedly in the role. A second search brought in Dr. Bill McKinney. Interview subjects were careful to distinguish this from dysfunction-driven churn.

"The fact that they had to then hire another person within two years is just a total fluke."

GINA SNYDER

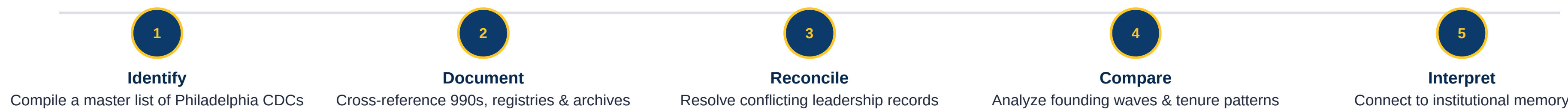
7 Broader Implications

Documenting CDC histories reveals how community-based organizations build, hold, and sometimes lose the knowledge that keeps a mission alive. That knowledge doesn't always stay inside one organization: several directors moved directly between Philadelphia CDCs (Fairmount to Mt. Airy, Tacony to PARC, Mt. Airy to the Welcoming Center), carrying relationships and know-how with them.

8 Conclusion

Philadelphia CDCs are shaped as much by the leaders who serve them as by the communities they were built to support. Where a leader's knowledge cannot be fully transferred within one organization, it may still persist at the level of the sector, carried by directors as they move between CDCs, suggesting institutional memory in Philadelphia's CDC world is sectoral as much as organizational.

9 Research Process



10 Data Sources & Limitations

Primary sources: IRS Form 990 filings, PA corporate registries, CDC/PACDC directories, and local news archives. Many CDCs are small and volunteer-reliant, so records are often incomplete or conflicting, a limitation that is itself part of this project's finding.

11 Acknowledgments

With thanks to Professor Dilworth and the Drexel STAR Research Program for their guidance, and to the CDC leaders who shared their time and stories: Leo Dillinger IV (Germantown United CDC), Gina Snyder (formerly East Falls Development Corp.), Rick Sauer (PACDC), and Patrick Sherlock (Parks and Broad).

I started off juggling nothing, and by the end I was juggling a hundred things. You can't just hand somebody twenty balls and have them juggle them all.

GINA SNYDER, EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR, EAST FALLS DEVELOPMENT CORP., 2003–2017